ANCIENT GAME. MODERN LEADERSHIP.

TIMELESS LESSONS FROM THE MAHJONG TABLE



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PARALLEL SIX

Master the Art of the Pivot

"We cannot direct the wind, but we can adjust the sails."

—Nautical Proverb

Leadership Expectation: Deliver results while remaining alert to changing conditions, demonstrating the judgment and courage to adjust plans, priorities, and approaches when needed to achieve the objective.

Leadership Reality: Organizations reward leaders for commitment and execution, yet conditions rarely remain stable. Markets shift, assumptions prove false, and priorities change. After investing significant time, energy, and resources in a plan, changing course can feel riskier than pressing ahead—even when the evidence suggests otherwise.

Mahjong Moment

In Mahjong, players talk often about pivoting, the ability to deftly change direction from a targeted line to a new one based on what has happened in the course of play. It's a critical skill in the game because a promising hand can collapse quickly.

You have a strong hand. The win feels certain. Then an opponent exposes the exact tiles you need. What looked like a winning hand is no longer viable.

In one recent game, I was just two identical tiles away from Mahjong. Then the player to my right discarded one of them, and the next player called it, exposing all four copies on her rack. Just like that, my path to Mahjong had nearly disappeared.

Fortunately, I'd managed to hang on to a few tiles that helped to keep another option alive, and I pivoted. I didn't win that hand, but I came close. It was a reminder that in Mahjong, as in leadership, flexibility often matters more than certainty.

My favorite Mahjong student is my granddaughter, Josephine. At the age of six, I taught her a simplified version of the game, where players need just nine tiles instead of fourteen in order to declare Mahjong. I was elated when she also became obsessed with the game. She was particularly fond of the Red Dragons. She loved them so much that she refused to discard them, even when it was the only move that would allow her to win.

We laughed about it, but I was reminded that we, as adults, do the same thing. We cling to ideas, projects, strategies, and ways of working because they've become familiar.

Sometimes the hardest move in Mahjong—and in leadership—is letting go of the very thing you're most attached to.

Leadership Parallel

Leaders often stay committed to a path longer than they should. Sometimes it's ego—the need to prove we were right. Other times, it's inertia—the tendency to keep moving in the same direction because changing course feels harder than staying with the original plan.

The cost of delay is often greater than the cost of adjustment. Effective leaders reassess assumptions, monitor what is changing, and notice when new signals emerge. They create options early and keep multiple paths open. And they don't confuse persistence with discipline.

Persistence is staying committed to the goal. Discipline is knowing when a change in plan is required to achieve the larger objective.

Case in Point: The Varying Degrees of Pivots

Not all pivots are created equal. Some are small, the daily adjustments that keep work moving forward. Others are defining moments that reshape an entire organization. While no one can predict the future, every leader can be better prepared to respond when circumstances change.

And some pivots begin by recognizing where the world is already headed.

After Hurricane Irma and several damaging tropical storms swept through Southwest Florida, the owner of a growing hardscape company recognized a long-term reality: the Gulf Coast would continue to experience powerful storms, and those impacted communities would continue rebuilding for years to come.

A few years after launching his business, he and another small business owner joined forces, expanding their core services to include site preparation and demolition—both critical post-hurricane services. It required investing in big equipment, developing new expertise, and building a trusted network of skilled subcontractors. It was a calculated risk, grounded in what they believed the region would need—not just today, but years into the future.

Just a few months later, Ian—a Category 4 hurricane with sustained winds of 150 mph—struck Southwest Florida. The region was devastated.

Demand for demolition and site preparation surged. Because they had already started to expand their businesses, they were positioned to meet the need, reallocating crews and equipment to help home and business owners begin the long process of rebuilding. Years later, that work remains a significant part of the company's success.

They didn't know when the next storm would arrive. But they did make sure their businesses would be ready when it did.

The best pivots aren't reactions to the storm. They come from recognizing patterns, anticipating what they mean, and preparing before change arrives.



Research Spotlight

McKinsey research found that companies scoring highest on agility achieved three-year revenue growth rates more than 60 percent higher than the least agile companies.[1]

At the enterprise level, pivots are highly visible and often consequential. Organizations that fail to pivot can serve as cautionary tales. Companies like Blockbuster and Eastman Kodak didn't become irrelevant because they lacked resources. They became irrelevant because they lacked the fortitude to pivot.

To prepare for uncertainty, many organizations use disciplined scenario planning, asking themselves:

What if new legislation passes?

What if a vendor's supply chain fails?

What if a formidable competitor enters or exits our space?

What if we face a PR crisis highlighted on social media?

They consider the implications of each scenario and create response plans for something that may never happen—allowing for a quick pivot if needed.



Research Spotlight

More than half of executives say scenario planning and strategic foresight would significantly strengthen organizational resilience, yet fewer than 30 percent use these tools to guide decisions—and only 5 percent conduct simulations to prepare for geopolitical risks.[2]

The COVID-19 pandemic forced one of the largest global pivots in modern history. When the virus began spreading, almost every organization was pushed to adapt. Offices emptied overnight. Supply chains were disrupted. Leaders had to make critical decisions with conflicting information. Entire business models changed in a matter of weeks.

At the time, I was leading peer forums for chief HR officers across industries. Because of the pandemic and the increasingly critical role of HR executives, we started hosting more frequent and virtual forums. Initially, I brought everyone together in the same discussions, believing that organizations could learn from one another's experiences.

It quickly became clear that one group faced challenges unlike any other.

Healthcare.

While many organizations were figuring out how to transition employees to remote work, hospital leaders were confronting life-and-death decisions every day. They were managing unprecedented staffing shortages and navigating constantly changing clinical guidance. Some of our clients were caring for patients with the earliest known cases of COVID-19 in the country.

Recognizing that their unique challenges called for a different approach, we pivoted.

We set up a dedicated forum and connected the HR leaders from health systems across the country, creating a space where they could learn from one another in real time.

They shared workforce strategies, approaches to supporting clinicians and staff, communication plans, mental health resources, crisis staffing practices, and even insights for securing scarce protective equipment. Every conversation helped another organization respond a little faster—and often a little better.

The world had to pivot. We had to pivot. Healthcare leaders had to pivot because lives depended on it.

Play It Out

Change is hard. There is an entire discipline, *change management*, designed to help humans effectively move through change. And when the need for change is on the horizon, it rarely comes with complete information. Leaders are often tempted to wait until the path forward is clear before acting, missing the opportunity to shape the future.

Consider these two scenarios:

Scenario 1: Waiting for Certainty

Jamie leads a division of a professional services firm known for its high-quality work, experienced consultants, and strong client relationships. For years, the firm's reputation has been built on expertise, insightful analysis, and attention to detail.

As artificial intelligence begins dominating the business press, members of Jamie's leadership team start asking questions: Should we be using AI? Where could it make our jobs easier? What are our competitors doing?

Jamie is skeptical. "The technology isn't mature enough," she says.

"There are too many legal and quality concerns. Let's watch what others do with it and see what mistakes we can avoid." The team concedes and moves on.

Over the next year, competitors begin experimenting with AI-assisted research, proposal development, and content creation. Consultants who once spent hours gathering information and analyzing data can now complete similar work in a fraction of the time.

Clients begin asking different questions: What is your AI strategy? How are you using technology to improve efficiency? Why does this analysis take two weeks when other firms can deliver it in three days?

Jamie reassures the team that quality still matters most. And she is right. But quality is no longer the only thing clients are evaluating.

As competitive pressure increases, the team is forced to work longer hours to try and keep pace. For a while, they succeed. But then, margins begin to shrink. Employee burnout increases. Clients start choosing competitors that deliver similar quality faster and at a lower cost.

Scenario 2: Learning through Experimentation

Jamie leads a division of a professional services firm known for its high-quality work, experienced consultants, and strong client relationships. For years, the firm's reputation has been built on expertise, thoughtful analysis, and attention to detail.

As artificial intelligence begins dominating the business press, members of Jamie's leadership team start asking questions: Should we be using AI? Where could it make our jobs easier? What are our competitors doing?

Jamie has concerns about quality, confidentiality, legal implications, and the risk of overreliance on technology. But she is also curious to assess the potential efficiencies and opportunities AI might create.

Rather than waiting for a defined roadmap, Jamie decides to learn through experimentation. She forms a small pilot group of consultants, researchers, and operations staff. Their mandate is simple: explore using approved AI tools for low-risk work and share what they learn.

The group begins testing AI for meeting summaries, internal research, and knowledge management. Each week, the pilot team shares lessons learned with the broader organization. Confidence grows, and training is developed. Guidelines and governance frameworks are established. Team members become more comfortable using AI to enhance—not replace their expertise.

When clients ask about the firm's AI capabilities, Jamie's team has answers grounded in experience. They can discuss the benefits, risks, and practical applications they have spent months learning.

The organization is not just keeping pace with their competitors; it is getting ahead of them.

Reflection

Same leader. Same technology. Same uncertainty.

The difference is the leader's willingness to try new things and change course when needed.

The question to ask: **What signals am I seeing today that may require a different approach tomorrow?**

Through a Different Lens—Seeing Around Corners

When I asked Clark to describe himself as a leader, his answer reflected the mindset that has guided him through multiple business and career pivots.

"On my best days, I wake up focused on removing barriers for my team," he told me. "I'm always looking for options. There are usually many paths we can take to get after our shared goals."

He's also quick to acknowledge what happens when that perspective gets lost.

"On my worst days, I'm both reactionary and laser-focused," he admitted. "I'm reacting to the crisis of the day while executing on the plan that's in front of me, not paying enough attention to what may be shifting around us."

A commercially minded workforce strategist, Clark spends much of his time looking two to three years ahead. He's an innate systems thinker, scanning for patterns, anticipating challenges, and considering what might be around the next corner.

That commitment to looking ahead—and around corners—has served him well throughout his career.

One of the most significant pivots that Clark experienced came as the for-profit higher education industry faced increasing headwinds— regulatory scrutiny, declining public sentiment, new competitors, shifting employer demands, and broader questions about the value of traditional programs. The status quo was no longer an option.

Clark helped lead a strategic shift that materially altered how his organization, a nationally recognized for-profit higher education institution, approached the market.

Historically, employer partnerships focused on tuition funding and admissions. Clark challenged the leadership team to ask, “What workforce problems are employers trying to solve?” instead of, “How do we enroll more students?”

That simple question led to an entirely different conversation.

Instead of focusing on enrollment numbers, the university doubled down on helping companies address skills gaps, workforce planning, and leadership pipelines.

The pivot wasn’t easy.

“There was resistance,” Clark recalled. “People were comfortable with what had worked before.”

Then he shared an observation that applies to almost every pivot a leader will face.

“People tend to hold on tight to what worked yesterday, even when the market is signaling that tomorrow will be different.”

What ultimately helped build support was an enduring belief.

“Always put the client first. In our case, that was students and their employers. Help them solve the problems they are facing today. If you position the customer as your north star, the business case for change becomes much clearer.”

That same principle steered him through another major pivot earlier in his career.

When the research & advisory firm he worked for was acquired by a Fortune 500 company, the logo wasn’t the only thing that changed. While the two organizations operated in a similar space, their business models were quite different.

They were no longer selling research repositories to HR managers and directors. They were advising chief HR officers on enterprise-wide business challenges.

“We were selling a very different product to a very different audience. Honestly, it was scary at first.”

The value proposition shifted from access to information to highly personalized advisory support. The price point was higher. The sales cycle lengthened. The skills required to succeed became more sophisticated. “I had to make the shift myself before I could help my team make the leap,” Clark explained.

That meant learning how to speak to CHROs, understanding their priorities, and coaching his team to operate at a higher level. Instead of focusing on products and features, they learned to focus on executive challenges and business outcomes.

“The hardest part in all of this was helping people let go of a model that had made them successful,” he reflected. The transition required experimentation, coaching, and a willingness to learn on the fly. “We learned to fail fast and move on.”

Having worked alongside Clark, I have seen firsthand how his curiosity, optimism, and determination enable him to pivot when others become stuck. He views obstacles as problems to solve rather than reasons to stop.

That quality of resilience matters because successful pivots are rarely the result of a single decision. Rather, they emerge from a series of adjustments, experiments, and course corrections.

What stands out most about Clark and his stories is not that he predicts every change correctly. It’s that he remains willing to learn, adapt, and move forward when circumstances change.

Like skilled Mahjong players, great leaders rarely finish with the hand they were dealt. Success comes from anticipating what’s around the corner and letting go of strategies that no longer fit.

It requires courage to pivot before circumstances force your hand.

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

- Where might I be holding onto a strategy or approach that no longer fits?
- What new information or changing conditions require greater adaptability?
- How effectively does my team respond to change or uncertainty?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

- What has changed in our environment that should cause us to rethink our approach?
- What external changes could affect our strategy over the next six months?
- Where are we holding onto a plan simply because we've invested time or resources in it?
- How can we encourage people to raise concerns earlier?
- What contingency plans should we begin developing now?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

- Do I demonstrate the right balance between persistence and adaptability, or do I sometimes hold onto plans longer than I should?
- When circumstances change, how effectively do you think I recognize the need to adjust course and communicate that change to others?
- What is one thing I could do differently to become more agile and responsive as a leader?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

- I will reassess one initiative or approach that no longer seems effective.
- I will communicate changes in direction more clearly and consistently.
- I will identify one long-standing practice that no longer fits our current reality.
- I will revisit assumptions before moving forward on an important decision.
- I will reinforce learning and resilience during periods of change.

Parallel Six — Master the Art of the Pivot

1. Simon Blackburn, Laura LaBerge, Clayton O'Toole, and Jeremy Schneider, "The Drumbeat of Digital: How

2. Winning Teams Play," *McKinsey Quarterly*, June 2019.
Benedetta Berti, Ezra Greenberg, Geraldine Wessing, and Ziad Haider, "The Art, Science, and Technology of Geopolitical Scenario Planning," McKinsey & Company, June 10, 2026.

"Maureen translates hard-won lessons into ten vivid, memorable parallels that speak directly to what leaders actually struggle with: building culture, shaping employee experience, and forging real emotional connection with their teams."

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